SOCIOCULTURAL FALSE BELIEF #46 · GENDER ROLES AND EXPECTATIONS

“Real men don't cry or ask for help.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

Boys hear “Man up” and “Stop crying” from family, coaches, and peers. They learn to hide fear, sadness, and need, and later struggle to ask for help even when they are hurting. Many men carry pain silently for years.

What Scripture teaches

“Jesus wept.” David, a warrior king, wrote, “I am weary from groaning; all night I flood my bed with weeping.” Paul, a hardened apostle, said, “I will boast all the more gladly in my weaknesses, so that the power of Christ may rest on me... For when I am weak, then I am strong.” “Two are better than one... if one falls down, his companion can lift him up.” The strongest Man who ever lived wept, asked His friends to stay with Him, and received help carrying His cross. Strength includes honesty and humility.

> *“Jesus wept”* (John 11:35).

Also see

> “I am weary from groaning; all night I flood my bed with weeping and drench my couch with tears” (Psalm 6:6).

> “But He said to me, ‘My grace is sufficient for you, for My power is perfected in weakness.’ Therefore I will boast all the more gladly in my weaknesses, so that the power of Christ may rest on me. That is why, for the sake of Christ, I delight in weaknesses, in insults, in hardships, in persecutions, in difficulties. For when I am weak, then I am strong” (2 Corinthians 12:9–10).

> “Two are better than one, because they have a good return for their labor. For if one falls down, his companion can lift him up; but pity the one who falls without another to help him up!” (Ecclesiastes 4:9–10).

> “Carry one another’s burdens, and in this way you will fulfill the law of Christ” (Galatians 6:2).

Common self-statements

- Men do not show weakness.
- I should handle it myself.
- Crying is for the weak.
- Asking for help means I am less of a man.
- I have to be the rock.
- I cannot let anyone see me struggle.

Common logical errors

- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing a man is either strong or weak.
- Mind reading: Assuming others will lose respect.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling vulnerable and concluding it is unsafe.
- Fortune telling: Predicting that I will be dismissed.

Challenging questions

- Who taught me that real men do not cry or ask for help?
- What did Jesus, David, and Paul do?

- What does silence cost me and the people I love?
- Which men do I respect, and are they really emotionless?
- Who could I trust with something real?
- What is one small step I could take?

Truth summary

> Strength includes honesty. Jesus wept, David wept, and Paul embraced weakness. I can feel, speak, and ask for help, and that makes me a better husband, father, friend, and follower of Christ.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Weakness
- Pride
- Humility
- Friendship
- Depression, Symptoms of

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Divorce
- Self-Esteem, Low

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Just Be Held — Casting Crowns
God's care remains when control, strength, or explanations run out.

Praise You in This Storm — Casting Crowns featuring Phil Wickham
Suffering and tears do not establish that God is absent or uncaring.

I Am Not Alone — Kari Jobe
God's companionship remains through darkness, weakness, and uncertainty.

Blessed Assurance — Larry Ford and Lillie Knauls with Gaither
This classic hymn celebrates belonging to Christ and resting in His salvation.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "Real men don't cry or ask for help"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"Real men don't cry or ask for help." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Who taught me this?
- ☐ What did Jesus do?
- ☐ What does silence cost?
- ☐ Whom do I respect?
- ☐ Whom can I trust?
- ☐ What is my next step?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ Jesus wept.
- ☐ David poured out his tears to God.
- ☐ When I am weak, then I am strong.
- ☐ Two are better than one.
- ☐ Asking is wise.
- ☐ Honesty builds trust.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ John 11:35
  "Jesus wept."
- ☐ 2 Corinthians 12:9–10
  "But He said to me, 'My grace is sufficient for you, for My power is perfected in weakness.' Therefore I will boast all the more gladly in my weaknesses, so that the power of Christ may rest on me. That is why, for the sake of Christ, I delight in weaknesses, in insults, in hardships, in persecutions, in difficulties. For when I am weak, then I am strong."
- ☐ Ecclesiastes 4:9–10
  "Two are better than one, because they have a good return for their labor. For if one falls down, his companion can lift him up; but pity the one who falls without another to help him up!"

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Strong enough to ask: Each week, note one time you named a feeling or asked for help.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, John 11:35 becomes: "Tom can write: "Jesus wept, and I can be honest too.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Weakness" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- [ ] Name the rule. Write who taught you and what they said.
- [ ] Find a trusted man. Choose a friend or mentor.
- [ ] Say one real thing. Share a feeling or need.
- [ ] Read Psalm 6. Notice David's honesty.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "Real men don't cry or ask for help": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Strong enough to ask
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~Real men don't cry or ask for help.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I learned to hide what I feel. Teach me the strength of honesty and the humility to ask for help. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

SOCIOCULTURAL FALSE BELIEF #47 · GENDER ROLES AND EXPECTATIONS

“A good woman puts everyone else first.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

Girls often learn to be helpful, agreeable, and self-sacrificing. Mothers modeling endless giving, church examples of serving, and praise for “selflessness” can leave women exhausted and resentful, unsure whether they are permitted needs of their own.

What Scripture teaches

Paul urges, “in humility consider others more important than yourselves. Each of you should look not only to your own interests, but also to the interests of others.” Notice “not only.” Jesus said to love your neighbor “as yourself,” which assumes caring for yourself. Jesus Himself withdrew to rest and pray. The woman of Proverbs 31 buys fields, manages her household, and “opens her mouth with wisdom.” Serving others is godly. Erasing yourself is not what Scripture asks.

> *“Do nothing out of selfish ambition or empty pride, but in humility consider others more important than yourselves. Each of you should look not only to your own interests, but also to the interests of others”* (Philippians 2:3–4).

Also see

> “Strength and honor are her clothing, and she can laugh at the days to come. She opens her mouth with wisdom, and faithful instruction is on her tongue” (Proverbs 31:25–26).

> “So God created man in His own image; in the image of God He created him; male and female He created them” (Genesis 1:27).

> “For by the grace given me I say to every one of you: Do not think of yourself more highly than you ought, but think of yourself with sober judgment, according to the measure of faith God has given you” (Romans 12:3).

> “There is neither Jew nor Greek, slave nor free, male nor female, for you are all one in Christ Jesus” (Galatians 3:28).

Common self-statements

- If I take time for me, I am selfish.
- Everyone else comes first.
- My needs do not count.
- A good woman never says no.
- I must keep everyone happy.
- I am responsible for others’ happiness.

Common logical errors

- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing I am either selfless or selfish.
- Mind reading: Assuming others will think I am selfish.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling guilty and concluding that I am wrong to rest.
- Fortune telling: Predicting that everything will fall apart if I say no.

Challenging questions

- Who taught me that goodness means self-erasure?
- What does Scripture say about looking to others' interests "not only" my own?
- What happens to me when I never rest?
- What would I tell my daughter or a friend?
- What would a healthy balance look like?
- What is one need I can meet this week?

Truth summary

> I am a person made in God's image, with worth and needs. Serving is good, and so is rest, boundaries, and care for myself. Loving my neighbor as myself includes myself.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Tired
- Humility
- Love, For Others
- Guilt/Shame

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Pride

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

This Is Amazing Grace — Phil Wickham
Christ bears the burden of rescue rather than demanding self-salvation.

Is He Worthy — Andrew Peterson
Honest recognition of a broken world can lead to hope in Christ's final restoration.

Jesus Loves Me — Gaither Vocal Band
This familiar hymn places confidence in Jesus' love rather than personal strength.

If We Are the Body — Casting Crowns
The church is called to welcome and care for people rather than exclude or shame them.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "A good woman puts everyone else first"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"A good woman puts everyone else first." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Who taught me this?
- ☐ What does "not only" mean?
- ☐ What happens when I never rest?
- ☐ What would I tell a friend?
- ☐ What balance is healthy?
- ☐ What need can I meet?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ I am made in God's image.
- ☐ Look to others' interests, not only my own.
- ☐ Love your neighbor as yourself.
- ☐ Rest is godly.
- ☐ I can say no.
- ☐ My needs matter too.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ **Philippians 2:3–4**
  "Do nothing out of selfish ambition or empty pride, but in humility consider others more important than yourselves. Each of you should look not only to your own interests, but also to the interests of others."
- ☐ **Genesis 1:27**
  "So God created man in His own image; in the image of God He created him; male and female He created them."
- ☐ **Romans 12:3**
  "For by the grace given me I say to every one of you: Do not think of yourself more highly than you ought, but think of yourself with sober judgment, according to the measure of faith God has given you."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Care for myself too: Each week, note one need you met and one kind no.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Philippians 2:3–4 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I can care for others' interests and my own.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Tired" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- [ ] List your needs. Write what you need in body, mind, and spirit.
- [ ] Say one kind no. Decline one thing this week.
- [ ] Schedule rest. Block an hour for yourself.
- [ ] Read Mark 12:31. Notice "as yourself."

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "A good woman puts everyone else first": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Care for myself too
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~A good woman puts everyone else first.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I have poured out until I am empty. Teach me to serve with joy, rest with permission, and care for the life You gave me. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

SOCIOCULTURAL FALSE BELIEF #48 · GENDER ROLES AND EXPECTATIONS

“I'm not a real man or woman if I don't measure up.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

Culture, family, and church set lists of what “real” men and women do: earn, protect, cook, parent, look a certain way. Singleness, infertility, job loss, illness, or differing gifts can feel like failing at manhood or womanhood.

What Scripture teaches

“God created man in His own image; in the image of God He created him; male and female He created them.” Our identity as God’s image-bearers is given, not earned. “Do not think of yourself more highly than you ought, but think of yourself with sober judgment, according to the measure of faith God has given you.” Deborah judged Israel, and Hannah wept in infertility, yet both were honored. Paul says, “There is neither Jew nor Greek, slave nor free, male nor female, for you are all one in Christ Jesus.” Our standing is in Christ, not in a checklist.

> *“So God created man in His own image; in the image of God He created him; male and female He created them”* (Genesis 1:27).

Also see

> “For by the grace given me I say to every one of you: Do not think of yourself more highly than you ought, but think of yourself with sober judgment, according to the measure of faith God has given you” (Romans 12:3).

> “Now Deborah, a prophetess, the wife of Lappidoth, was judging Israel at that time” (Judges 4:4).

> “In her bitter distress, Hannah prayed to the LORD and wept with many tears” (1 Samuel 1:10).

> “There is neither Jew nor Greek, slave nor free, male nor female, for you are all one in Christ Jesus” (Galatians 3:28).

Common self-statements

- A real man provides.
- A real woman has children.
- I am failing at being who I should be.
- I do not fit the mold.
- Others measure up and I do not.
- My circumstances prove I am less.

Common logical errors

- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing I either fit the standard or am inadequate.
- Mind reading: Assuming others see me as less.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling inadequate and concluding that I am.
- Fortune telling: Predicting that I will never measure up.

Challenging questions

- Who set the list I am measuring myself against?
- Which items come from Scripture, and which from culture?
- What does Scripture say about my identity?

- Who do I admire who does not fit the mold?
- How would I counsel a friend with the same circumstances?
- What are my gifts and calling right now?

Truth summary

> I am made in God's image and secure in Christ. Manhood and womanhood are not a checklist I must pass. I can grow in character and use my gifts, knowing my worth is not up for a vote.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Pride
- Gifts, Physical/Material
- God, Creator
- Love, By God

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Love

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Who Am I — Casting Crowns
Being known and cared for by God rests on His love rather than personal importance.

You Say — Lauren Daigle
God's loving assessment challenges identity based only on weakness or feelings.

Is He Worthy — Andrew Peterson
Honest recognition of a broken world can lead to hope in Christ's final restoration.

Jesus Loves Me — Gaither Vocal Band
This familiar hymn places confidence in Jesus' love rather than personal strength.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I'm not a real man or woman if I don't measure up"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I'm not a real man or woman if I don't measure up." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Who set the list?
- ☐ Scripture or culture?
- ☐ What does God say?
- ☐ Whom do I admire?
- ☐ What would I tell a friend?
- ☐ What are my gifts?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ I am made in God's image.
- ☐ My identity is given, not earned.
- ☐ I can think of myself with sober judgment.
- ☐ God honored Deborah and Hannah.
- ☐ I am one in Christ.
- ☐ I have gifts and a calling.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Genesis 1:27
  "So God created man in His own image; in the image of God He created him; male and female He created them."
- ☐ Romans 12:3
  "For by the grace given me I say to every one of you: Do not think of yourself more highly than you ought, but think of yourself with sober judgment, according to the measure of faith God has given you."
- ☐ Galatians 3:28
  "There is neither Jew nor Greek, slave nor free, male nor female, for you are all one in Christ Jesus."

A verse I found myself: _____

_____

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Secure in Christ: Each week, note one way you used your gifts without comparing.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Genesis 1:27 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I am made in God's image, and my identity is secure in Christ.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Self-Esteem, Low" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- [ ] Write the list. Note the standards you measure yourself against.
- [ ] Sort the list. Mark which are from Scripture and which are culture.
- [ ] Honor your gifts. Write five things you do well.
- [ ] Memorize Genesis 1:27. Say it when you feel less.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I'm not a real man or woman if I don't measure up": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Secure in Christ
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I'm not a real man or woman if I don't measure up.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I have measured myself by lists. Remind me that I am Your image-bearer, secure in Christ, with gifts to use. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

SOCIOCULTURAL FALSE BELIEF #49 · GENDER ROLES AND EXPECTATIONS

"I must be the strong one, no matter what."

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

The oldest child, the caregiver, the spouse who "keeps it together," or the one who learned early that no one else would. Others depend on us, and we feel we have no right to fall apart. Over time, exhaustion, resentment, and isolation build.

What Scripture teaches

Paul says, "My grace is sufficient for you, for My power is perfected in weakness." "Cast your burden upon the LORD and He will sustain you." "Come to Me, all you who are weary and burdened, and I will give you rest." "Carry one another's burdens." Moses needed Aaron and Hur to hold up his arms. We are not meant to be the source of strength for everyone. God is. Our job is to lean on Him and let others share the load.

> *"Cast your burden upon the LORD and He will sustain you; He will never let the righteous be shaken"* (Psalm 55:22).

Also see

> "But He said to me, 'My grace is sufficient for you, for My power is perfected in weakness.' Therefore I will boast all the more gladly in my weaknesses, so that the power of Christ may rest on me. That is why, for the sake of Christ, I delight in weaknesses, in insults, in hardships, in persecutions, in difficulties. For when I am weak, then I am strong" (2 Corinthians 12:9–10).

> "Come to Me, all you who are weary and burdened, and I will give you rest. Take My yoke upon you and learn from Me; for I am gentle and humble in heart, and you will find rest for your souls. For My yoke is easy and My burden is light" (Matthew 11:28–30).

> "Carry one another's burdens, and in this way you will fulfill the law of Christ" (Galatians 6:2).

> "Two are better than one, because they have a good return for their labor. For if one falls down, his companion can lift him up; but pity the one who falls without another to help him up!" (Ecclesiastes 4:9–10).

Common self-statements

- If I fall apart, everything falls apart.
- No one else can handle this.
- I do not get to be weak.
- Others depend on me.
- I have to hold it together.
- I cannot let anyone down.

Common logical errors

- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing I am either strong or a failure.
- Mind reading: Assuming others cannot cope without me.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling needed and concluding that I cannot stop.
- Fortune telling: Predicting disaster if I rest.

Challenging questions

- When did I first become “the strong one”?
- What would really happen if I rested or asked for help?
- Who could share some of the load?
- What does God say about being sustained?
- What have I lost by never leaning?
- What is one thing I can hand off?

Truth summary

> God is the strong one. I can cast my burdens on Him, let others share the load, and rest. My weakness is not the end of the world. It is where His power is seen.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Tired
- Weakness
- Trust
- Friendship
- Anxiety/Worry

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Divorce

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Just Be Held — Casting Crowns
God’s care remains when control, strength, or explanations run out.

Praise You in This Storm — Casting Crowns featuring Phil Wickham
Suffering and tears do not establish that God is absent or uncaring.

Living Hope — Phil Wickham
Christ’s resurrection and forgiveness provide hope beyond sin and death.

Blessed Assurance — Larry Ford and Lillie Knauls with Gaither
This classic hymn celebrates belonging to Christ and resting in His salvation.

Each morning ask: “If I truly believed God’s truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?”

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I must be the strong one, no matter what"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I must be the strong one, no matter what." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ When did this begin?
- ☐ What would really happen?
- ☐ Who could help?
- ☐ What does God say?
- ☐ What have I lost?
- ☐ What can I hand off?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ God sustains me.
- ☐ His power is perfected in weakness.
- ☐ Jesus gives rest to the weary.
- ☐ We carry burdens together.
- ☐ Others can share the load.
- ☐ I can rest.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Psalm 55:22
  "Cast your burden upon the LORD and He will sustain you; He will never let the righteous be shaken."
- ☐ 2 Corinthians 12:9–10
  "But He said to me, 'My grace is sufficient for you, for My power is perfected in weakness.' Therefore I will boast all the more gladly in my weaknesses, so that the power of Christ may rest on me. That is why, for the sake of Christ, I delight in weaknesses, in insults, in hardships, in persecutions, in difficulties. For when I am weak, then I am strong."
- ☐ Galatians 6:2
  "Carry one another's burdens, and in this way you will fulfill the law of Christ."

A verse I found myself: _____

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- ☐ Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- ☐ Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ Lean and rest: Each week, note one load you shared or handed off.
- ☐ My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Psalm 55:22 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I will cast my burden on the Lord and He will sustain me.""
- ☐ Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ Reading: The "Tired" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- ☐ List your loads. Write everything you carry.
- ☐ Hand off one. Ask someone to take one task.
- ☐ Rest on purpose. Schedule real rest.
- ☐ Pray Psalm 55:22. Cast your burden daily.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I must be the strong one, no matter what": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Lean and rest
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I must be the strong one, no matter what.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I have been the strong one for too long. I cast my burdens on You. Sustain me, and send people to share the load. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

SOCIOCULTURAL FALSE BELIEF #50 · GENDER ROLES AND EXPECTATIONS

“My role is fixed, and I can't be more than that.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

Family, culture, or church may tell us who we are allowed to be: the helper, the provider, the quiet one, the one who never leaves. Dreams are dismissed, abilities overlooked, and we shrink to fit. Eventually we forget what we wanted.

What Scripture teaches

“I praise You, for I am fearfully and wonderfully made.” God’s gifts are given to each person, and Paul says the body has many parts, each needed. “Do not think of yourself more highly than you ought, but think of yourself with sober judgment, according to the measure of faith God has given you.” Deborah was a prophetess who judged Israel, and Lydia led a business. God calls people in many ways. While Christians differ on some roles in marriage and church, nobody has the right to say you cannot grow in the gifts God gave you.

> *“For by the grace given me I say to every one of you: Do not think of yourself more highly than you ought, but think of yourself with sober judgment, according to the measure of faith God has given you”* (Romans 12:3).

Also see

> “For You formed my inmost being; You knit me together in my mother’s womb. I praise You, for I am fearfully and wonderfully made. Marvelous are Your works, and I know this very well” (Psalm 139:13–14).

> “The body is a unit, though it is composed of many parts. And although its parts are many, they all form one body. So it is with Christ” (1 Corinthians 12:12).

> “Now Deborah, a prophetess, the wife of Lappidoth, was judging Israel at that time” (Judges 4:4).

> “There is neither Jew nor Greek, slave nor free, male nor female, for you are all one in Christ Jesus” (Galatians 3:28).

Common self-statements

- This is all I am allowed to be.
- I cannot change what is expected of me.
- My dreams do not matter.
- It is too late to be anything else.
- I was born for this role only.
- People would not accept me in another role.

Common logical errors

- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing I am either in my role or out of place.
- Mind reading: Assuming others will not accept growth.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling stuck and concluding that I am.
- Fortune telling: Predicting that I cannot change.

Challenging questions

- Who assigned my role, and was it God, family, or culture?

- What gifts do I have that my role does not use?
- What does Scripture say about gifts?
- What did I dream of before I learned to shrink?
- Where might I grow while remaining faithful to my commitments?
- Who could encourage me?

Truth summary

> God gave me gifts and calling beyond a label. I can honor my commitments and responsibilities while growing in the gifts He gave. My worth and my potential are not limited by someone else's script.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Gifts, Physical/Material
- Will of God
- Guidance
- God, Creator

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Thinking, Healthy

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Who Am I — Casting Crowns
Being known and cared for by God rests on His love rather than personal importance.

You Say — Lauren Daigle
God's loving assessment challenges identity based only on weakness or feelings.

If We Are the Body — Casting Crowns
The church is called to welcome and care for people rather than exclude or shame them.

Great Is Thy Faithfulness — CeCe Winans
This classic hymn recalls God's steady mercy through changing circumstances.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

My Plan for Replacing "My role is fixed, and I can't be more than that"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"My role is fixed, and I can't be more than that." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Who assigned my role?
- ☐ What gifts go unused?
- ☐ What does Scripture say?
- ☐ What did I dream?
- ☐ Where can I grow?
- ☐ Who can encourage me?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ I am fearfully and wonderfully made.
- ☐ God gave me gifts.
- ☐ The body has many parts.
- ☐ I can think of myself with sober judgment.
- ☐ I can grow.
- ☐ My worth is not limited by a script.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ **Romans 12:3**
  "For by the grace given me I say to every one of you: Do not think of yourself more highly than you ought, but think of yourself with sober judgment, according to the measure of faith God has given you."
- ☐ **Psalm 139:13–14**
  "For You formed my inmost being; You knit me together in my mother's womb. I praise You, for I am fearfully and wonderfully made. Marvelous are Your works, and I know this very well."
- ☐ **1 Corinthians 12:12**
  "The body is a unit, though it is composed of many parts. And although its parts are many, they all form one body. So it is with Christ."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

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- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
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  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Growing in my gifts: Each week, note one step of growth.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.
  For example, Romans 12:3 becomes: "Sarah can write: "God gave me gifts, and I can grow in them.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Will of God" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- [ ] Name your gifts. Write what you do well.
- [ ] Revisit a dream. Write what you once hoped to do.
- [ ] Take one small step. Try a class, a skill, or a conversation.
- [ ] Seek encouragement. Ask a trusted friend or mentor.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "My role is fixed, and I can't be more than that": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Growing in my gifts
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Tue				
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Thu				
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My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
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My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~My role is fixed, and I can't be more than that.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, You made me with gifts. Free me from scripts that shrink me. Show me how to grow faithfully and use what You gave me. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.